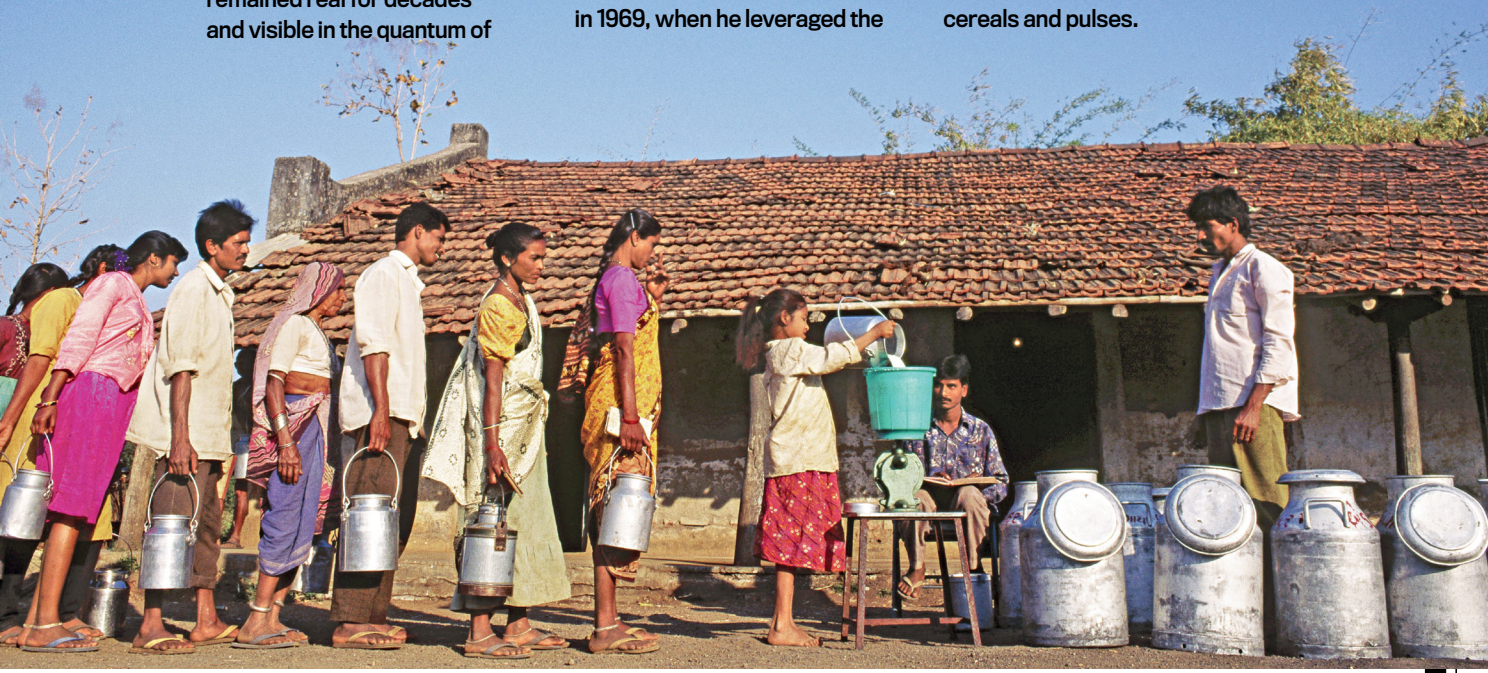
The Amul Model

In 1951, India produced 17 million tonnes of milk a year with per capita availability of 5 ounces daily. Scarcity—in milk, its products, baby food—remained real for decades and visible in the quantum of imports. Verghese Kurien, the milkman of India, had established the viability of milk cooperatives as early as in 1952. Even though every prime minister from Nehru to Indira Gandhi recognised the Kurien model, the idea could not get past systemic sloth. Kurien achieved a breakthrough only in 1969, when he leveraged the milk aid from FAO-WFP to fund the national grid for milk. His 'billion litre' idea catalysed Operation Flood, creating incomes for millions of rural households. Thanks to that Milk Revolution, India is counted as the world's largest producer of milk with an output of 210 MT. It creates an economic value larger than of cereals and pulses.



INDIA PICTURE

Bank Nationalisation

India knew in 1947 that it didn't have the resources to fund its ambitions. Its savings rate was barely 11 per cent. The political class was convinced that business houses had colonised savings. It was Subhadra Joshi who first articulated the idea of nationalisation. Coming at the intersection of economics and politics, it gathered subscription as India needed investment capital and Indira Gandhi needed political capital to dethrone the syndicate in the Congress. In July 1969, the ownership of 14 banks was transferred to the government, enabling it to access funds through the mechanism of SLR, addition of 50,000 branches and aggregation of funds. In 2022, the policy may trigger revulsion, but there's no denying its role in enabling development. There's no disputing either that it took 40 years and a 12-digit revolution for the country to see financial inclusion.



INDIA PICTURE

Mid-Day Meals

At Independence, India had a literate population of a mere 18.3 per cent. Poverty thwarted enrolment and perpetuated illiteracy. Victor Hugo had first evangelised the correlation between feeding children and enrolment. K. Kamaraj introduced the idea in 1955; MGR expanded it in Tamil Nadu in 1982. Soon, it caught on across states, and chief ministers campaigned for a national programme at the National Development Council through the '80s. In 1991, nearly a third of children didn't attend school, malnutrition was rising and India trailed even its neighbours, with literacy lagging at 52 per cent. Universalisation of the mid-day meal scheme (MDMS) came in phases, first in 1995 and after a Supreme Court intervention in 2001. Two decades later, several studies have validated the impact of MDMS, enrolment is in the 90s and girls outnumber boys in schools. Yet, a quarter of our population is still not literate.